

Pastéis de Nata

Ingredients

Pastry Dough

250 g plain flour

5 g fine sea salt

150 ml cold water

Butter Layer

225 g unsalted butter, *softened but not melted*

Custard

300 ml whole milk

200 g caster sugar

100 ml water

30 g plain flour

1 cinnamon stick

1 strip lemon peel (no white pith)

6 large egg yolks

1 tsp vanilla extract (optional)

Pinch of salt

Fruit base (optional)

150g Frozen berries

1 tsp lemon juice

1 tbsp sugar

To Serve

Ground cinnamon

Icing sugar (optional)

Preparation Steps

Make the Dough

1. Mix the flour and salt in a large bowl.
2. Gradually add the cold water while stirring until a shaggy dough forms.
3. Knead for 8–10 minutes until smooth and elastic.
4. Shape into a rectangle.
5. Wrap and refrigerate for 30 minutes.



Laminate the Pastry

First Butter Layer

6. 1. Lightly flour the bench.
2. Roll the dough into a rectangle approximately 40 × 25 cm.
3. Spread one-third of the softened butter evenly over the top two-thirds of the dough.
4. Fold the unbuttered third over the centre.
5. Fold the remaining third over the top, like folding a letter.
6. Wrap and chill for 20 minutes.

Second Fold

7. Rotate the dough 90°.
8. Roll back into a long rectangle.
9. Spread half of the remaining butter over the top two-thirds.
10. Fold into thirds again.
11. Chill for another 20 minutes.

Final Fold

12. Rotate the dough another 90°.
13. Roll into a rectangle once more.
14. Spread the remaining butter evenly over the entire surface.
15. Roll the dough tightly into a log from the long edge.
16. Wrap tightly in plastic wrap.
17. Refrigerate for at least 2 hours (overnight is even better).

Make the Custard

18. Combine the sugar, water, cinnamon stick and lemon peel in a saucepan.

Bring to a boil.

Simmer for 3–4 minutes until the syrup reaches approximately 106°C.

Remove the cinnamon stick and lemon peel.

19. Make the milk base, in separate bowl

Whisk the flour with a few tablespoons of the milk until smooth.

Add the remaining milk.

Heat gently while whisking until the mixture thickens.

Remove from the heat.

20. Slowly pour the hot sugar syrup into the milk mixture while whisking continuously.

21. Allow the mixture to cool for about 10 minutes.

22. Whisk in the egg yolks one at a time.

23. Stir in the vanilla, if using.

24. Strain the custard through a fine sieve.

25. Cover and allow to cool.

Prepare the Pastry

26. Preheat the oven to **250°C** (or as hot as your oven will safely go).

27. Grease a standard 12-hole muffin tin.

28. Slice the chilled pastry log into 12 equal pieces.

29. Place each piece cut-side up into a muffin cup.

30. Wet your thumbs with cold water.

31. Press each piece from the centre outward, working the pastry up the sides until it forms a thin shell. The bottom should remain slightly thicker than the sides.

Assemble

32. (Optional) if using the fruit filling place small dollop at the bottom of the shell

33. Fill each pastry shell about three-quarters full with custard.

34. Do not overfill, as the custard will expand during baking.

Bake

35. Bake for 15–18 minutes.

36. The pastry should be deeply golden and crisp.

37. The custard should be set with dark brown or black blistered spots on top.

38. If needed, place under a very hot grill for 1–2 minutes to achieve additional caramelisation.

Serve

39. Cool in the tin for 5 minutes.

40. Transfer to a wire rack.

41. Dust with ground cinnamon.

42. Dust lightly with icing sugar if desired.

43. Serve warm on the day they are baked.